



IN THE MIX:
Karthikeyan with
driver Saran



ROOKIES: Patel (top) Shelar (bottom left) and Kini (bottom right) and his team of 10 mechanics. They dissect drives in English and Tamil and stand over the cars as an open heart surgery is performed. Karthikeyan is in the mix measuring the track temperature, timing practice laps, the team always trying to squeeze just a bit more out of the car. "All you need to win," says NK Racing team manager Yohann Setna, "is to be one hundredth of a second faster than the next guy."

For the first time in his life, as a test

driver for Williams F1, Karthikeyan, 30, is being paid to drive. There is a possibility of more F1 races. So why bother with 18-hour working days that do not guarantee that extra one-hundredth of a second? Karthikeyan says, "I wanted to start something in a small way, we had all the infrastructure in our workshop." Until 12 years ago, a section of Perur Engineering Works, part of his father's business, worked on cars the teenage rookie raced. Today that garage is buzzing again.

Karthikeyan has worked his net-

work of contacts to get his team what it needs, like F1 lubricants from Castrol. With Balu, he teaches rookies how to log every detail of a drive into their memories to use as feedback.

Karthikeyan and Setna have designed a new easy-to-read set-up sheet for the pit team. The sheet logs the suspension and chassis set-up—tyre pressure, ride height/ ground clearance, angle of the tyres—which changes every time the car goes out, depending on the track surface and weather.

The team was trimmed from four